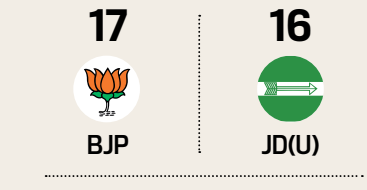


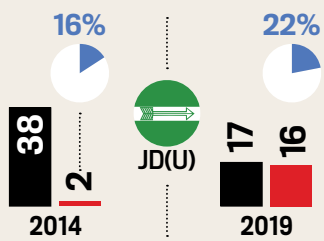
ANI

THE JUNIOR PARTNER

As part of the NDA, the JD(U) is contesting one seat less than the BJP this Lok Sabha election



Figures denote number of NDA candidates in the fray



● SEATS CONTESTED
● SEATS WON ● VOTES

a poor show can hasten the endgame.

Needless to say, the spotlight has unwaveringly stayed on Nitish, especially after his return to the BJP fold. It was in saffron company that the JD(U) had secured a simple majority in the 2020 assembly polls, only to abandon it in August 2022 and forge a 17-month-long government with Tejashwi Yadav, now his principal opponent. "By making these frequent flip-flops, Nitish Kumar the politician has completely destroyed the credibility and image of Nitish Kumar the governance man," says Prem Chandra Mishra, former Congress MLC and All India Congress Committee media panelist.

His partymen immediately spring to his defence. Says Rajib Ranjan, a former MLA and JD(U) spokesman: "Nitish Kumar scripted Bihar's turnaround, ensuring our state achieved one of the fastest growth rates in India. He also empowered the most marginalised sections, including women, extremely backward classes (EBCs) and Scheduled Castes (SCs). This makes him relevant not only today but for years to come."

The greater challenge for Nitish is having to play the junior partner in the alliance with the BJP. At 16 seats, the JD(U) is contesting one seat less than in 2019 and also a seat less than the BJP, which is contesting 17, the same as last time. Bihar still has two phases and 16 seats left to go for the polls. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has taken the lead in campaigning, embarking on eight tours in the state to address a dozen public meetings. His aggressive campaigning aims to solidify support for the NDA. Tejashwi, meanwhile,